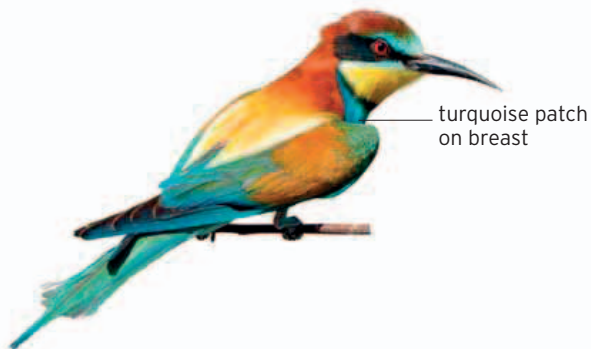


turquoise patch
on breast

long, triangular wing

European bee-eater

Merops apiaster

European bee-eaters live up to their name—their food largely comprises bees and wasps with minor variations according to location and season. The birds are partially immune to the insects' venom, but take care to remove the stings before swallowing the bees. They show a preference for the nonvenomous drones, particularly selecting such harmless food for their young.

Chorus singers

European bee-eaters can be seen roosting in rows on telephone wires, or in small groups on dead trees. Flying out to catch prey, they glide on flat, fully-stretched wings with bursts of quick beats. Even their calls draw attention—the chorus of rich, chirruping notes is a familiar sound in much of southern Europe. Migrating flocks sometimes number more than 100 birds, held together by almost constant calling.

Bee-eaters nest in colonies that range from a handful of nests up to hundreds, and large colonies are busy places bustling with noise and activity. Initially, the birds tend to fight while defending their nest hole and nearby perch. Breeding pairs may last for life, and their

behavior is often interchangeable. It is only when the male feeds the female—helping to cement the pair bond and also to build up nutrients before egg-laying—that the sexes can be told apart. Four to seven eggs hatch after 20 days, and the chicks are fed in the nest for a month. The chicks continue to roost in the nest hole for a while after fledging, and families often migrate together in fall, spending the winter in Africa.

► CONTROLLED LANDING

Bee-eaters have sleek and streamlined bodies. Their long, triangular wings and long tails allow them to maneuver with ease as they accelerate, twist, and turn to catch flying insects in mid-air.

curved,
dagger-
shaped billwide tail with
central spike

A bee-eater must eat about **225 bee-sized insects every day**